

on the scoreboard

by lester rodney

This and That

THERE IS SOME question whether Bill Russell, the fabulous basketball All American from San Francisco now on the Olympic team, will come east to play with the Boston Celtics after the Australian festivities. He was the Celts first draft choice, obtained from the St. Louis Hawks, who got Ed Macauley and Cliff Hagan in the deal. (Macauley wanted to play in his home town of St. Louis anyhow, so it was a convenient deal all around.) Russell, key man of what many call the finest college team ever, is also being wooed, needless to say, by the Harlem Globetrotters, who have been going downhill as a real court powerhouse for want of the good big man. And undoubtedly he has offers from the AAU "amateur" industrial group out west, where he is known and would be a drawing card.

Whether he decides to go pro—as we heard—or not, one thing is certain. The Celtics desperately want him and will go high. They completely discount the theory that he won't make the pros anyhow because he "can't shoot." In the first place a man with his height, spring, reflexes and speed hardly has to have much of a shot too far from the basket, and in the second place he showed with San Francisco he could develop a good hook shot and jump shot. His scoring of 20 and more for part of the game while leading the Olympians to two straight over the Phillips Oilers was all Boston needed to know about whether he could score in the pros. The Oilers are pros in actual fact, and good ones.

★

OUR Knicks met up with another west coast product, Willie Naulls of UCLA, Wednesday night at St. Louis, and probably agree that the hard rebounding speedy, dead eyed 6-5 rookie has helped make the Hawks contenders. They fought back from a 20 point deficit to within 89-83 with seven minutes left, then Naulls came back in, blocked a shot by Sears, fed Pettit for a quick goal, scored another on a driving rebound and the Hawks were home free. Pettit, Macauley, Naulls and Coleman, backed by Share, make up a formidable front court indeed. Returned Irv Bemoras in the backcourt, a good one, may need more help but as it stands, this club still could leap all the way to the top as Philadelphia did last year.

★

PING PONG, which you're supposed to call table tennis for some commercial reason which has become obscure, has become a big international competitive sport. Twenty-four countries, including ours, will send teams to Stockholm for the championships next spring. The Cechs and Japanese are the "teams to beat."

★

GIANT FANS may remember Andy Cohen, who came to the Polo Grounds as a second baseman with quite a splash. Andy, a good journeyman ballplayer, never did become another Rogers Hornsby, whom he followed, but after playing out his spell in the minors, turned to managing and is highly rated. He just moved up the ladder from New Orleans in the Southern Association to Indianapolis, Triple A farm of the Cleveland Indians in the American Association. Which move may signify that the new Indian manager is Kerby Farrell, who managed Indianapolis to the flag last season.

★

WHAT DID THE "selling" of Ebbets Field mean? Primarily it was a real estate and tax deal, like the selling of Yankee Stadium by the Yanks. And it probably also fits into the pattern of O'Malley pressure for the building of the new Stadium in downtown Brooklyn.

★

ANSWER TO QUERY: Yes, we had the right to go to the Olympics, it was a question of money.